

Phase 2: Market Research

5 candidate ideas based on the problems that came up in the Phase 2 interviews:

Real-Time Food Availability System

Problem Statement: Students sometimes travel to a campus dining location, expecting a specific food item only to discover that it is sold out or unavailable. This can waste time and cause students to spend additional money on another meal. One student, for example, found the BBQ ribs unavailable only after reaching the counter and then spent about \$6 extra on a snack.

Candidate Idea: Create a system that displays real-time availability for individual food items and dining stations, marking them as Available, Low Stock, or Sold Out.

Dining Hours and Service Status Tracker

Problem Statement: Posted business hours do not always tell students whether every part of a dining location is operating. A participant arrived while a café was open but discovered that its kitchen had already closed, resulting in an \$18 delivery order and roughly a 40-minute wait.

Candidate Idea: Provide live operating information for each dining location, including separate kitchen/counter hours, temporary closures, equipment outages, and service changes.

Flexible Meal Plan with Rollover Balance

Problem Statement: Students are concerned about paying for meal-plan funds they may lose if they do not use them before they expire. Multiple interviewees said rollover was important because they wanted to receive the full value of the money they paid.

Candidate Idea: Design a meal plan that allows unused money to roll over into the next semester and gives students a clear view of their remaining balance and spending.

Customizable Meal Plan Options

Problem Statement: Students have different eating and spending habits, so one meal-plan structure may not work well for everyone. Some interviewees preferred a dollar balance because it provides flexibility, while others preferred a set number of meals because it is easier to manage.

Candidate Idea: Allow students to choose between different plan structures, such as dollar-balance plans, set-meal plans, or a combination of both, based on their needs and budget.

Campus Dining Alerts and Notifications

Problem Statement: Students often do not learn about sold-out items, equipment failures, or restocking problems until they physically arrive at the dining location. One participant lost about ten minutes because an espresso machine was down and specifically said an equipment-outage notification would have helped.

Scoping Decision:

Our team decided to narrow the project to a Real-Time Campus Dining Availability System. The interview evidence showed that one of the most repeated problems was students arriving at a dining location and discovering that an item, station, or service was unavailable even though the information they checked beforehand did not show the change. Students reported sold-out ribs, missing sandwiches, empty grab-and-go cases, sold-out soup, and other unavailable items that caused wasted time, substitutions, or extra spending. Because this issue appeared across multiple interviews and had clear consequences, we chose to focus on a system that provides current item and station availability before students walk to a dining location.

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Jacob	Date	9/9/26
Time	9:00 am	Location	Union
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Sophomore

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

This morning I checked the UTEP dining app for Tech Café's opening time before heading over.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

It was open on time and the full breakfast menu was available.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

A few weeks ago the espresso machine at Orange and Brew was down and a sign said no lattes. I found out once I got to the counter.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I got a regular coffee instead. It cost the same, but I lost about ten minutes waiting behind people asking about it.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I picked Tech Café over the dining hall because I already knew their menu and didn't want to check anything.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Once this month. A notification for equipment outages would help.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes ☒ No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Jacob	Date	9/9/26
Time	9:45 am	Location	CCSB
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Commuter student

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

Last week I checked Google for Chick-fil-A's hours before driving to campus early.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

It matched. Everything was open as listed.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

Two weeks ago the grab-and-go fridge at the Union was empty when I got there around 8am. I only found out by looking inside the case myself.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I bought a granola bar from a vending machine instead. It cost about \$2 more and I was still hungry until lunch.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose the vending machine over checking another dining option because I didn't have time to look anything up.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Twice this month. Knowing whether the grab-and-go case was restocked yet would help most.

Optional follow-up contact: ☒ Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Email

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Jacob	Date	9/9/26
Time	10:30 am	Location	Union
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Senior

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

On Tuesday I checked Panera's website for the soup of the day before walking over.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

The soup listed was actually already sold out by the time I got there around 11.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

That was the most recent surprise. A staff member told me at the register.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I ordered a sandwich instead. It cost about \$2 more than I planned to spend.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose Panera anyway over the dining hall because I still trusted their sandwich menu even without the soup.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Just once this month. A real-time update on soup availability would help.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes ☒ No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Jacob	Date	9/9/26
Time	11:30 am	Location	Union
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Senior

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

Earlier this week I checked the posted hours outside El Sazón Minero before a lunch meeting.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

It was open, but they had run out of the catering trays listed for walk-up orders.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

That was the most recent time. A staff member behind the counter told me when I asked.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I picked something else off their regular menu. It didn't cost extra, but the meeting started a few minutes late.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose El Sazón Minero over Pick 'N' Shovel because I already knew their regular menu even without the special trays.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Once this month. Knowing ahead whether catering trays were still available would have saved time.

Optional follow-up contact: ☒ Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Microsoft Teams

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Jacob	Date	9/9/26
Time	12:45 pm	Location	CCSB
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Freshman

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

Yesterday I checked the dining hall's weekly menu online before walking over for lunch.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

Most of what was listed was there, but the dessert station was already cleared out.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

That was the most recent surprise. I noticed when I got to that station and it was empty.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I just skipped dessert and didn't spend anything extra, but I was a little annoyed.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose the dining hall over Chick-fil-A because I had already paid for my meal plan.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Once this month. Knowing which stations were still stocked in real time would help.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes ☒ No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Jacob	Date	9/9/26
Time	2:00 pm	Location	Union
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	JR

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

This morning I checked Orange and Brew's hours on my phone before an afternoon meeting.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

It was open, but they were out of oat milk, which I usually get.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

That was the most recent surprise. The barista told me when I ordered.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I got regular milk instead. It didn't cost more, but I wasn't thrilled with it.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose Orange and Brew over Tech Café because I already knew the coffee was reliable even with that one substitution.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Once this month. Knowing which milk options were in stock would have helped.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes ☒ No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Salvador Rodarte	Date	9/9/26
Time	9 am	Location	Union
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	First-year student with meal plan

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

Yesterday I checked the UTEP dining page before walking to Pick 'N' Shovel. It showed breakfast and the menu.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

It was open and everything was available.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

Last week the bbq ribs were out and done. I found out from a paper sign after I reached the counter.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I bought a snack and waited until after class for a full meal. I spent about \$6 extra and was hungry during class.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose Chick-fil-A because I knew its menu and did not want to risk another unavailable dining-hall item.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Two times. A live notice that ribs were out would have been cool.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Salvador Rodarte	Date	9/9/26
Time	9:35 am	Location	Union
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Junior Engineering

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

On Monday I checked the campus dining page for Orange and Brew. Everything was normal.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

Everything was available, except sandwiches.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

A week ago a grab-and-go case was empty at lunch. I did not know until I reached the store.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I walked to Union and bought pizza from the Hut. The detour took about 25 minutes out of my study time.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose Pizza Hut because I knew the menu and could see that the counter was open.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Twice. The actual available menu would have changed me walking all the way there.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Salvador Rodarte	Date	9/9/26
Time	11:10 am	Location	CCSB
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Senior vegetarian student

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

Last Thursday I used the Panera app to check vegetarian lunch options before going to the Union.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

The menu matched, but the tomato soup for-go was sold out when I arrived around 12:30 pm.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

That was the latest surprise. The cashier told me after I had waited in line with a bunch of freshmen.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I ordered a salad instead. It cost about \$3 more, and I did lose time.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose Panera over a rotating campus counter because its menu and ingredient list are more predictable and I didn't want to walk.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

About two times. Current item-level availability for vegetarian choices would have helped most.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Microsoft Teams

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Salvador Rodarte	Date	9/9/26
Time	12:25 pm	Location	CCSB
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Graduate student

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

I did not check last Thursday. I relied on the hours and menu I remembered from the week before.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

The cafe was open at 6:30 pm, but the kitchen was closed and only coffee and pastries were available.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

A staff member explained that the kitchen closes earlier than the cafe. I had not seen that posted online.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I ordered delivery to the lab. It cost about \$18 and took roughly 40 minutes.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose the nearby pizza place over a familiar chain because it was closer.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Once. Separate hours for the kitchen and the coffee counter would have prevented it.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Email

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Salvador Rodarte	Date	9/9/26
Time	1:50 pm	Location	CCSB
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Graduate Student

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

Last week I checked the Chick-fil-A app for lunch hours and the sandwich menu before walking over.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

The hours and menu matched what was available at the counter.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

The last surprise was several months ago when the waiting time was super long and I just could not be bothered.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I ordered only the sandwich. It did not add time or cost enough to affect my day.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose Chick-fil-A over a dining counter because I already knew the menu and expected it to be consistent.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

Zero times this month. I usually choose familiar places; accurate break-period hours are the main detail I need.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Phase 2 Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Salvador Rodarte	Date	9/9/26
Time	2:00 pm	Location	CCSB
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Graduate student living in campus

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. Tell me about the last time you checked a campus dining menu or hours before walking to a location. Where did you look, and what did you expect to find?

Yesterday I checked the weekly dining-hall menu on my phone, I hoped to find some buffet options that are common.

2. When you arrived, what was actually open and available? What, if anything, differed from the information you checked?

They had very limited options from the list available and they were not serving anymore.

3. Tell me about the most recent time a sold-out item, closed counter, or changed hours caught you by surprise. Where did it happen, and how did you find out?

I found out from after going into the menu with a friend and we had already paid.

4. What did you do next? How much extra time or money did the change cost you?

I stayed and used a meal swipe and ate mostly pizza. I did not spend extra, but it was not what I planned to eat.

5. Tell me about the last time you chose between a place whose menu you already knew and one you needed to check. What did you choose, and why?

I chose the dining hall over a chain because I had already paid for the plan so it was for the best.

6. In the past month, how many times has missing or incorrect menu or availability information changed your plan? In the most recent case, what one detail would have helped?

One time in the last month but this is common occurrence. A same-day notice about substituted no more food being served.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Text

INTERVIEWER FACILITATION SHEET

Campus Dining Menu and Availability • Phase 2

BEFORE THE CONVERSATION

- Choose someone with a recent experience checking or relying on a campus menu, posted hours, or food availability. Avoid relying only on one friend group.
- Use a role or descriptor only; do not record the participant's full name.
- Get verbal permission before taking notes. Never record without asking.
- Give the participant the response sheet. They can write short answers while you listen and ask follow-ups.

OPENING SCRIPT

“I’m a student researching recent experiences with campus dining menus, hours, and food availability. I’m not selling anything. I want to understand what happened the last time you checked or relied on this information. Is it okay if I take a few notes while we talk?”

MOM TEST RULES — KEEP THESE IN FRONT OF YOU

- 1. Talk about their life, not your idea.** Do not pitch an app, website, new meal plan, or proposed solution.
- 2. Ask about specific past behavior.** Use “last time,” “most recent,” “what happened,” and “what did you do?” Avoid “would you use...?”
- 3. Listen more than you talk.** If you have spoken for more than two sentences, stop and ask a follow-up question.

USE THESE FOLLOW-UP PROBES

• Tell me more about that.	• What happened next?
• How did that affect you?	• What did you do about it?
• How did you figure that out?	• How long did that take?
• Has that happened more than once recently?	• What did you use or ask for help?

WHAT TO LISTEN FOR

- Sources checked: campus pages, restaurant apps, posted signs, staff, friends, or memory.
- Accuracy gaps: posted menus or hours differ from what is open and available on arrival.
- Location patterns: familiar chains may be predictable while dining halls and rotating counters change.
- Consequences: extra walking, delays, added cost, substitutions, leaving campus, or skipping food.
- Repeatability and disconfirming evidence: count recent incidents and record when the information worked.

CLOSING

- Ask: “Who else should I talk to about this?”
- Ask whether they are okay with a later follow-up if needed.
- Thank them for their time.

AFTER THE INTERVIEW — COMPLETE WITHIN 24 HOURS

Strongest exact quote	“I arrived at 6:15 pm, but the door was locked and a paper sign said it had closed at 6:00 pm.”
Repeatable problem?	* Yes ☐ No
One-sentence takeaway	The recurring problem is trusting whether posted hours, counters, and specific items are still available.

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Daniel Lozano	Date	9/8/26
Time	12:00 PM	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Junior 1

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. 1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

Pretty comfortable and the most I would pay for 950 – 1000 dollars per semester.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

Just something I can enjoy eating but also it's healthy and not just junk food.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

Dollar balance to spend on.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

Dietary preferences would affect what plan I choose.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

It is very important to me because I want it to carry on for me, so I can use it.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would prefer to pay monthly payments for a meal plan.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Microsoft Teams

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Daniel Lozano	Date	9/8/26
Time	12:10 PM	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Senior 1

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. 1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I would feel comfortable with spending money for a meal plan and I would want it to be under \$1000 if possible.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

It would be worth the price to me if I was able to get an adequate amount of food from the meal plan each time I used it.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would prefer a set of meals for my meal plan.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

Allergy-friendly options would affect the meal plan I choose.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

It is important to me that they roll over, because I don't want my money to go to waste.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would prefer to pay for it all at once.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Daniel Lozano	Date	9/8/26
Time	12:30 PM	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Senior 2

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I would feel sort of comfortable, but it depends on the meal plan itself.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

It would feel worth it if the meals had good variety in what we could get.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would prefer a meal plan with a set of meals because it fits the way I like to eat and would work best for me.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

It would not really affect which meal plan I choose.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

It is important to me for the sake of getting my money's worth.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would prefer to pay for it in monthly payments.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Daniel Lozano	Date	9/8/26
Time	12:40 PM	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Graduate Student

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I would not feel comfortable spending money on a meal plan.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

What would make the price feel worthwhile to me would be the price for it not to be too high.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would rather have the dollar balance to spend for the meal plan.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

It would not affect which meal plan I choose.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

It is very important because it's my money that I spend.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would rather pay all at once assuming it would be part of the total towards my tuition.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Daniel Lozano	Date	9/8/26
Time	12:50 PM	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Senior 3

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I would feel comfortable spending 500 – 800 dollars on a meal plan.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

It would feel worth it if there was different places the meal plan would be able to work at.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would prefer the dollar balance for the meal plan because I feel a set of meals is too limiting a day.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

The allergy-friendly option would affect the meal plan I chose.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

It is important to me because I would rather have my money be completely used than have a small portion of it be wasted.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would prefer to pay for the meal plan all at once.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Microsoft Teams

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Daniel Lozano	Date	9/8/26
Time	1:00 PM	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Staff Member

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I would feel comfortable spending money on a meal plan if the price wasn't too bad.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

It would feel worth the price to me if the meal plan was enough so that I was able to feel full throughout the whole day.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would prefer the meal plan to be with the set of meals because I find that if the dollar balance will just make me feel like I have more to spend than I do.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

This would not affect the meal plan I would choose.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

I would say it is very important to me for my unused money to roll over and not expire.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would prefer to pay through monthly payments because I feel it would be too much all at once.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes * ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional):

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Daniel Lozano	Date	9/8/26
Time	2:00 pm	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Junior 2

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I would only feel comfortable if I felt the meal plan was something I really needed and if the price was right.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

It would be worth it to me if the portion sizes were bigger ones and the food had variety to what we could choose from.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would prefer the dollar balance if it meant the next day would have the left over money included.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

I think dietary preferences would definitely affect which meal plan I would choose.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

It is very important for it to roll over for me.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would prefer to pay through monthly payments due to the nature of the meal plan being a big expense all at once.

Optional follow-up contact: ☐ Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional):

INTERVIEWER FACILITATION SHEET

Campus Dining Hall Information • Phase 1

BEFORE THE CONVERSATION

- Choose someone with recent, real experience using or considering campus dining. Avoid relying only on one friend group.
- Use a role or descriptor only; do not record the participant's full name.
- Get verbal permission before taking notes. Never record without asking.
- Give the participant the response sheet. They can write short answers while you listen and ask follow-ups.

OPENING SCRIPT

"I'm a student researching people's experiences with campus dining, including food information, allergies and dietary needs, dining choices, and meal plans. I'm not selling anything. I just want to understand what you've actually experienced. Is it okay if I take a few notes while we talk?"

MOM TEST RULES — KEEP THESE IN FRONT OF YOU

- 1. Talk about their life, not your idea.** Do not pitch an app, website, new meal plan, or proposed solution.
- 2. Ask about specific past behavior.** Use "last time," "most recent," "what happened," and "what did you do?" Avoid "would you use...?"
- 3. Listen more than you talk.** If you have spoken for more than two sentences, stop and ask a follow-up question.

USE THESE FOLLOW-UP PROBES

• Tell me more about that.	• What happened next?
• How did that affect you?	• What did you do about it?
• How did you figure that out?	• How long did that take?
• Has that happened more than once recently?	• What did you use or ask for help?

WHAT TO LISTEN FOR

- Repeated problems: the same issue has happened more than once.
- Workarounds: they check multiple places, ask staff, skip a meal, go elsewhere, or track meal-plan use manually.
- Consequences: wasted time, uncertainty, missed meals, unused meal-plan value, or avoiding the dining hall.
- Strong evidence: a concrete recent story is more useful than general opinions or compliments.
- Disconfirming evidence: if the participant has no problem, record that too. Do not force the conversation toward the idea.

CLOSING

- Ask: "Who else should I talk to about this?"
- Ask whether they are okay with a later follow-up if needed.
- Thank them for their time.

AFTER THE INTERVIEW — COMPLETE WITHIN 24 HOURS

Strongest exact quote	
Repeatable problem?	☐ Yes ☐ No
One-sentence takeaway	

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Zachary Carrejo	Date	9/8/26
Time	5:00 pm	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Commuting Sophomore

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

Probably around \$500–\$700 per semester.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

If I was actually saving money compared to buying food normally and had a lot of places to choose from.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

A dollar balance because I could decide how much I want to spend each time.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

Not really for me personally, but I think having those options is important.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

Very important. I wouldn't want to lose money that I already paid for.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

Monthly payments would be easier for me.

Optional follow-up contact: Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional): N/A

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Zachary Carrejo	Date	9/8/26
Time	5:25 pm	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Commuting Freshman

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I would probably be comfortable spending around \$1,000–\$1,200 per semester.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

Having enough meals for most of the week and being able to use the plan at different restaurants would make it worth it.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would prefer a set number of meals because it would be easier for me to keep track of.

4. Would dietary or allergy-friendly options affect which meal plan you choose?

Yes. I would want healthy options and information about what's in the food.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

Very important. If I have meals or money left, I think I should be able to use it next semester.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would rather pay monthly so it's not one large payment.

Optional follow-up contact: Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional): N/A

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Zachary Carrejo	Date	9/9/26
Time	8:30 am	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Junior

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

Around \$600-\$800 a semester would be reasonable for me.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

I would want discounts and enough food choices so I don't have to eat the same thing all the time.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

Definitely a dollar balance. I don't eat the same amount every day.

4. Tell me about the last time you chose to leave campus for food instead of eating at UTEP.

No, I don't have any dietary restrictions, so it wouldn't really affect my decision.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

Very important. Expiring money would make me less likely to buy the plan.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would prefer monthly payments.

Optional follow-up contact: Yes * No Preferred contact method (optional): N/A

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Zachary Carrejo	Date	9/9/26
Time	9:30 am	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Graduate Student

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

Probably around \$400–\$600 per semester.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

I would want the meal plan to actually give me a discount compared with paying normally.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would prefer a dollar balance because some days I might only buy coffee or a snack.

4. Tell me about the last time you chose to leave campus for food instead of eating at UTEP.

Yes. Having healthier and dietary-friendly choices would make the plan more useful.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

It is important. At minimum, I would want unused money to remain available until the next semester.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would prefer monthly payments so I don't have to pay a large amount upfront.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Microsoft Teams

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Zachary Carrejo	Date	9/9/26
Time	9:45 am	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Student Living on Campus

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I would be comfortable with around \$1,200–\$1,500 per semester if I was using it almost every day.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

I would need a lot of food choices, enough meals for the week, and the ability to use it at different dining locations.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

I would prefer a set number of meals, especially if I knew how many meals I had available each week.

4. Tell me about the last time you chose to leave campus for food instead of eating at UTEP.

Yes. Even though I don't have allergies, I would want healthy options and clear information about the food

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

Very important. I don't think meals or money that I already paid for should just disappear.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

Monthly payments would be better because \$1,500 at once is a lot for a student.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Microsoft Teams

CAMPUS DINING HALL RESEARCH

Interview Response Sheet

Please answer briefly based on your actual campus dining experiences. Short phrases are okay. The interviewer may ask follow-up questions.

Interviewer	Zachary Carrejo	Date	9/9/26
Time	1:30 pm	Location	On campus
Phase	2	Subject descriptor	Senior

Do not write the participant's full name. Use only a role or descriptor (example: "commuting sophomore" or "faculty member").

QUESTIONS

1. How comfortable would you feel spending on a meal plan each semester?

I wouldn't want to spend more than about \$500 per semester because I'm not on campus every day.

2. What would make a meal plan feel worth the price to you?

A cheaper plan that lets me use the money whenever I am on campus would be worth it.

3. Would you prefer a meal plan with a set of meals or a dollar balance you can spend on?

A dollar balance would work better for me.

4. Tell me about the last time you chose to leave campus for food instead of eating at UTEP.

Not personally, but I would still expect the meal plan to have different food options.

5. How important is it to you for unused meal-plan money to roll over instead of expiring?

Extremely important. If the money expires, I feel like I'm wasting whatever I didn't use.

6. Would you prefer to pay for a meal plan all at once or through monthly payments?

I would rather pay it all at once if the plan is only around \$500.

Optional follow-up contact: * Yes ☐ No Preferred contact method (optional): Microsoft Teams

INTERVIEWER FACILITATION SHEET

Campus Dining Hall Information • Phase 1

BEFORE THE CONVERSATION

- Choose someone with recent, real experience using or considering campus dining. Avoid relying only on one friend group.
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- Give the participant the response sheet. They can write short answers while you listen and ask follow-ups.

OPENING SCRIPT

"I'm a student researching people's experiences with campus dining, including food information, allergies and dietary needs, dining choices, and meal plans. I'm not selling anything. I just want to understand what you've actually experienced. Is it okay if I take a few notes while we talk?"

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- 2. Ask about specific past behavior.** Use "last time," "most recent," "what happened," and "what did you do?" Avoid "would you use...?"
- 3. Listen more than you talk.** If you have spoken for more than two sentences, stop and ask a follow-up question.

USE THESE FOLLOW-UP PROBES

• Tell me more about that.	• What happened next?
• How did that affect you?	• What did you do about it?
• How did you figure that out?	• How long did that take?
• Has that happened more than once recently?	• What did you use or ask for help?

WHAT TO LISTEN FOR

- Repeated problems: the same issue has happened more than once.
- Workarounds: they check multiple places, ask staff, skip a meal, go elsewhere, or track meal-plan use manually.
- Consequences: wasted time, uncertainty, missed meals, unused meal-plan value, or avoiding the dining hall.
- Strong evidence: a concrete recent story is more useful than general opinions or compliments.
- Disconfirming evidence: if the participant has no problem, record that too. Do not force the conversation toward the idea.

CLOSING

- Ask: "Who else should I talk to about this?"
- Ask whether they are okay with a later follow-up if needed.
- Thank them for their time.

AFTER THE INTERVIEW — COMPLETE WITHIN 24 HOURS

Strongest exact quote	
Repeatable problem?	☐ Yes ☐ No

One-sentence takeaway	
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